



Junji Ito: Japanese Tales of the Macabre

Manga to creep you out and keep you up at night

Junji Ito is a very celebrated horror mangaka. If you're into reading manga then we bet that you've come across at least one of his works and if you've come across his works then you know how horror-inducing his visuals can get. If you've never read a manga before, we highly recommend that you read Uzumaki. But beware, it is NOT for the faint hearted. Just the visuals alone are enough to give you goosebumps. This trend continues throughout almost all the works of Junji Ito making him one of the legends in the Japanese Horror Manga scene. This guy really has figured out how to make a jumpscare work - ON PAPER! Anyways, coming to the review, Japanese Tales Of the Macabre is an anthology of 20 stories split into 12 episodes. Anthology means that each episode has a bite sized story which starts with the episode and ends with the episode. Although, a different approach was taken in this anthology series. Some

episodes are divided into two 10 minute stories rather than one big 20 minute story. This sometimes works in favour of the story and sometimes it works against it. Since the whole series does not have one big story, we cannot review all the 12 episodes but we sure can review a bunch that really stuck with us.

Spoilers start here. Skip to the end for a spoiler-free review. Hands down, the best episode in the entire series is the Hanging Balloons episode. The basic premise of the episode is that a Japanese pop star idol is found dead, mysteriously hanging from the powerline in front of her house. Her high school friends are traumatised from the event and soon they find out that giant human heads are floating in the air with a noose attached to them. These human heads have a pale skin colour and a horror-ish grin and they follow the person who has the same face. Also, if you're thinking about deflating them or burning them, you'd essentially

be signing your own death warrant since the person to which the balloon is related to will face the same fate i.e. the person too will either deflate completely or get burnt up. Honestly, this is just creepy and scary and the visuals from this episode stuck with us even after the show ended.

However, all episodes are not the same in this series. Hanging Balloons and some chosen few stories are the ones which are worth watching. Now, we know that the episode only has around 20 odd minutes to set up the whole narrative and background of the story and the characters AND tell the story but we found that around 50-60% of the stories just ended too abruptly or were too shallow. The main plot point of those stories was just not enough, even for a 20 minute story. The best example for this would be the Mysterious Tunnel story. The premise of this story is simple. There's a boy named Goro and his mother one day, vanishes into a dark tunnel. After he grows up, he decides to check out the tunnel for himself only to find that there is nothing in there except for a "Cosmic Ray Observatory". He finds himself mysteriously drawn to the tunnel and at the episode's climax, the tunnel's secret is revealed. The tunnel swallows people alive and leaves behind patches of blood. That's it. We found this story and many others to be really shallow. We think that stretching this story to a 20 minute runtime did not work in its favour.

The spoiler free review begins here. If you are in the mood to see some really nightmare-inducing visuals, blood, gore and just some borderline creepy stuff then this series could be for you. The stories, except for a chosen few, are really shallow and you will not connect with them on a deeper level. If you are expecting this series to be a horror series with jumpscare then we would suggest you look somewhere else. Although if you're looking for unsettling imagery that will definitely leave a mark, go ahead, give this one a try. We give it 3.5 stars out of 5.

-Kshipra Jadav